I Stopped Yelling to Get Us Out the Door in the Mornings

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For about six months, our mornings went like this: I'd wake my daughter up, and by the time we left the house I had said "PUT YOUR SHOES ON" roughly fourteen times, at increasing volume, while she did everything except put her shoes on. We left the house angry. Every day. She'd cry at drop-off, I'd feel like garbage all the way to work, and then we'd do it again tomorrow.

I tried the sticker chart. I tried racing her ("bet I get dressed faster than you!" — she did not care). I tried explaining, calmly, why mornings have deadlines, which was hilarious because she was three. The problem wasn't motivation. The problem was that she needed forty-five minutes to do what I thought took fifteen, and I kept pretending it took fifteen.

So here's the thing that actually worked, and it's embarrassingly simple: we started getting up earlier. Not 5am-mommy-blogger earlier. Twenty minutes earlier. That was it. The whole fix.

Twenty minutes of slack changed everything. When there's no time pressure, I don't bark. When I don't bark, she doesn't dig in. When she doesn't dig in, she gets dressed in ten minutes instead of thirty. The irony of it: the morning I stopped rushing her, we started leaving on time.

The second thing: I moved every decision to the night before. Clothes laid out (hers, mine — I was also losing ten minutes to my own closet), bag packed, lunchbox in the fridge with a sticky note so I don't forget it on the counter, shoes by the door. I know every parenting book says this. I know it's the most boring advice on earth. I resisted it for months because it felt like admitting defeat. It's the thing that worked.

The third thing is the one nobody told me: I stopped trying to get her out of bed with words. Words don't work on a half-asleep four-year-old. Now I just sit on her bed and be boring until she wakes up properly — no phone, no hurry, just me being a warm lump for five minutes. She gets up

on her own, grumbly but awake. Before, I was trying to negotiate with a creature that was essentially still dreaming, and then being surprised when it went badly.

What didn't work: the timer. Everyone swore by the timer. "When it beeps, shoes on!" Our daughter found the beep extremely interesting as a sound and completely irrelevant as an instruction. Also didn't work: me being perfectly calm while secretly seething, because she could smell it. Kids are lie detectors with juice boxes.

It took about three weeks for the new pattern to stick. There were still bad mornings — there still are, when someone's sick or we stayed up too late. But the baseline changed. We don't yell our way out the door anymore. We just… leave. Some days she even sings in the car. I'm still a little stunned by it.